



Niger



Niger lies in west Africa, upstream from Nigeria on the Niger River. One of the world's poorest states, it was ruled by one-party or military regimes until multipartyism was allowed in 1992.



GEOGRAPHY

The north and northeast regions are part of the Sahara. The Air Mountains in the center rise high above the desert. Savanna lies to the south.



CLIMATE

High temperatures persist for most of the year at around 95°F (35°C). The north is virtually rainless.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tuareg nomads in the north feel excluded from politics and the benefits of development of their area's uranium resources. An early 1990s rebellion was reignited in 2007. In the south, egalitarianism and a sense of community help to combat economic difficulties. Almost the entire urban population lives in slum conditions. Two-thirds of the population is under 25. Women have limited rights and restricted access to education.



THE ECONOMY

Vast uranium deposits. Frequent droughts and food shortages. Banditry. Expansion of Sahara. Oil potential.



INSIGHT: The name Niger comes from the Tuareg word *n'eghirren*, which means "flowing water"



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Niger

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Niamey

POPULATION: 15.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 489,188 sq. miles
(1,267,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 31 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Hausa, French*, other

RELIGIONS: Muslim 85%, traditional beliefs 14%, other (incl. Christian) 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Hausa 55%, Djermas and Songhai 21%, Peul 9%, Tuareg 9%, other 6%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes